

## **Benchmark Leadership Interview**

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### **Author Note**

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### **Leadership Interview**

Interviewing Dr. Kristy Burton about what leadership is like as a counselor-educator and association member was a privilege. Dr. Burton has a diverse background, with a bachelor's degree in criminal justice and a career with the Federal Bureau of Prisons (FBP) as a parole officer. She has had many leadership experiences from this career (which I will discuss in more detail below) and from her career as a counselor, counselor-educator, and association president. In her counseling practice, she has worked mostly with adults or adolescents aged thirteen and older with trauma clients and clients with co-occurring addictions. When we met over a Teams Meeting, she was preparing to teach a weekend intensive of John Brown University counseling students and adjusting to her new role as the president of the Arkansas Counselors Association (ARCA).

Dr. Burton has been in a leadership role at ARCA for 6 years. She also held the position of president for the Arkansas Supervision Board and the Arkansas Substance Abuse Certification Board. In these positions, she likes to be at the table but not run the table. Her adjustment to being the president of ARCA is mostly situated in how to run the table. Most of these roles were not sought out because of her experience with the FBP. In her career with them, she did seek out leadership roles primarily because it was expected. To be in the FBP or any federal organization, one does not simply settle for entry-level positions or find oneself succeeding by waiting for others to call on them, according to Dr. Burton. Because she sought these leadership positions out with the FBP, she burned out quickly and turned to a new career in counseling. According to Dr. Burton, the burnout occurred because she didn't desire leadership or feel fulfilled in leadership with the FBP; she simply did it because it was expected. I will speak more about what this taught me below.

Dr. Burton's leadership style is, simply stated, not to be in charge. She likes to function as part of a group, collaborate, and cooperate rather than be a single, stand-alone leader. In fact, as she talked to the current leadership of ARCA, she wanted to ensure that there was a well-established, well-functioning team in place. This fits well with her philosophy of leadership, which is to establish continuity and lead by mentoring. She prefers to teach by doing, remaining open to feedback, and giving good feedback. Leadership in the Federal system changed her perspective from leadership as a status symbol to leadership as a co-laborer. I appreciated this philosophical framework and found that it affirmed my desire to lead out of a desire to help and grow others, not a desire to be known. Hearing about her time with the FBP taught me that seeking leadership roles out of a motivation to please, a motivation to have more money, or a motivation to have more influence will only lead to burnout and disappointment.

The admonition from Dr. Burton to lead proactively vs. reactively has landed on my heart. Thinking about this statement has led me to the conclusion that I will need to arrange my schedule and my philosophical stance toward a vision that changes people. Most of my leadership experience has come from a practical philosophy (that is what I did rather than what I said I wanted) of wait and see. This sounded very much like a person-centered philosophy to me, and my soul resonated with my mission as a Christ-follower and counselor-educator. With this framework, Dr. Burton said, our approach to interaction and feedback changes. Our role as an educator changes. We begin to listen for understanding and how we can help others grow. I especially appreciated this view in regard to supervision.

She helped my view of association leadership as she made it more approachable and possible with her idea of leading a team. She helped my view of leadership in education as she showed me it can be a continuation of the skills and efficacies of counseling. She changed my

view of leadership in supervision as she acclaimed it was different than leading at the table. At the table of an association, there is no power differential between her and a team through the lens of her philosophy. In supervision, there is still a power differential between the supervisor and supervisee. Understanding that I must pay close attention to the relational aspects of supervision is new and helpful to me. I can remember desiring to have a collegial relationship with my internship supervisor but a friendship with my licensure supervisor. I'm thankful my licensure supervisor stewarded that relationship within the power differential until we had completed my hours.

As the interview continued, I soon grew curious about what our state needed in terms of leadership. Having a unique platform from which to view our state as a whole, I knew Dr. Burton would have a finger on the pulse of what the future looked like. Her opinion was that we needed to lean into the leadership of leaders and the supervision of supervisors. She was thankful that Arkansas has strict requirements for and a special license for supervisors but lamented that after licensure, there is no accountability. She has been involved in issues where the supervisor was acting unethically and perhaps illegally. I definitely sensed her parole officer mode click-on in this discussion. I'm not sure we should be in the business of micromanaging our supervisors. However, the idea of encouraging our leaders, supervisors, and educators to stay in relationships that challenge them sounds right to me. I had a pastor who used to say everyone needs a Paul and a Timothy in their life. In other words, everyone needs a mentor and a protégé. I wonder how this could be encouraged. I'm sure we could do research into how such relationships mediate and moderate compassion fatigue and burnout. I'm certain we could write articles concerning the practice and encourage all counselor-educators and leaders in the field to be aware of the

benefits. However, I believe the best route is to encourage emerging counselors to see the positive outcomes of relationships that build them up and challenge them.

One overarching theme that arose from this interview was the danger of isolation as leaders. Seeing ourselves at the top of the chain, untouchable and unteachable, has impacted Church leadership throughout its history. I am not privy to the goings on of state boards and discipline efforts, but I can't imagine it is much different for leaders in counseling who isolate. The lesson for me in this is to practice what I intend to preach. Who are my two? Who are my Paul and Timothy? Right now, I have a few Timothy's (and Tonya's), but I don't have a Paul (or Paulette). However, I am considering a change of setting that will transition me to a university role. In this role, I will have an active mentor/supervisor whom I respect and admire greatly. I hope that, if this transition is forthcoming, that I will benefit from her leadership and other leadership in the university. I will have fewer opportunities to be isolated in this role if I am hired. Currently, I isolate a great deal, and as I write this, it disturbs me.

I am honored to have benefitted from Dr. Burton's experience in leadership through this interview. I hope that we can continue our relationship, and perhaps the conversation will lead to leadership roles in the state. If not, I have gained knowledge and wisdom for how my leadership philosophy will impact others in my world.